

Ports of Plague

5-Minute Presentation Outline

Talking points for presenting the game to the class. Times are a guide; aim for about 5 minutes total, then take questions.

1. HOOK (0:00–0:30)

- "In October 1347, twelve Genoese galleys sailed into the harbor of Messina in Sicily, carrying a disease that would kill somewhere between a third and 60 percent of Europe." [TR-06, DB-01]
- "Our game asks: if you were a merchant then, would you keep trading?"

2. WHAT THE GAME IS (0:30–1:15)

- *Ports of Plague* is a board game for 1–6 players, played in a web browser: everyone shares one computer and takes turns, or each player uses their own phone while a big screen shows the map. Computer-controlled houses (Easy, Medium or Hard) can fill the other seats, so even one person can play. It has a painted map board, ships and carts sailing the trade routes, dice, cards and house banners, all animated.
- Each player is a merchant family based in a real trading city (Marseille, Genoa, Venice, Florence, Barcelona, London, Bruges, Lübeck). A dice roll at the start sets the turn order for the whole game.
- 12 rounds of half a year each (Late 1347 to Early 1353), or 4 rounds of a year and a half in **Quick Play** (about 20 minutes for 4 players), plus optional pre-plague rounds and a 30-second turn timer. Three difficulties, from Apprentice to Great Mortality. A game takes about 15–60 minutes.
- **Goal:** the highest *Legacy* in 1353 = Wealth + Family + Reputation, plus your weakest category again. **Balance beats greed.**

3. HOW IT PLAYS: STRATEGY AND CHANCE (1:15–2:15)

- On your turn you spend 2 action points (3 in Quick Play): ship goods, open trading posts, move or protect your family, consult a physician, or give to charity. Most actions take 1 point, but opening a trading post or moving your family takes 2, so expanding or fleeing means giving up other things that turn.
- **Merchant's Ledger:** once the plague has passed a city, you can arrange a marriage or buy abandoned land there. You can also take a loan, propose a partnership to another house, or close your city's gates to rivals. [SO-12, EC-02, EC-01, TR-04, SO-11]
- **Fortune cards:** roll a 6 on the profit die or open a trading post and you draw a personal card (spice cargoes, extra actions, warnings of where the plague goes next, but also illness and nervous creditors), so no two players' games are the same.
- **Chance:** a profit die, a contagion die (infected cargo), a severity die for each stricken city, and survival dice for family members.
- **Strategy:** sea routes pay more, but cargo from a stricken city can carry the plague, even bringing it to the next city one round early. Fleeing keeps your family safe but costs reputation. Paying to hold a ship offshore, as Venice made ships wait in 1348, stops infected cargo from spreading. [ME-12]
- Comeback rules: inheritance, weddings, loans, cheaper charity, and Guild's Favor (an extra action for a house far behind). No one is ever eliminated.

4. THE HISTORY INSIDE THE GAME (2:15–3:45)

- **Real timeline and trade routes:** the plague reaches each of the 45 cities, from Lisbon to Trebizond and from Oslo to Cairo, in the half-year it really did (Messina Oct 1347, Damascus July 1348, London Aug 1348, Bergen July 1349, Gibraltar 1350, Moscow 1353). [TR-06, CI-14, TL-08, TR-09, CI-19, TR-10]
- **Before the plague:** optional pre-plague rounds in 1346–47 let houses build their trade while only Caffa and Tana on the Black Sea are stricken. [TR-02, TR-12]
- **Social responses:** flight to the countryside (Boccaccio), the flagellants, and Pope Clement VI banning them in 1349. In Damascus, Muslims, Jews and Christians walked out together to pray for the plague to end. [SO-04, SO-02, SO-03, CI-14]

- **Persecution, handled seriously:** the Strasbourg massacre of February 1349 happened before the plague even arrived. The game states that the accusations were false, and players can only lose money by trying to protect the community, never gain. [SO-09, SO-07, SO-08]
- **Economy:** labor shortages raised wages and prices; England's Ordinance (1349) and Statute of Labourers (1351) tried to freeze wages and failed. [EC-03, EC-05, EC-06, EC-07]
- **Medicine:** the Paris Medical Faculty blamed the planets and "corrupt air"; physicians admitted they were helpless. The physician action shows real remedies such as bloodletting and figs and onions, and admits they did nothing. In Granada, Ibn al-Khatib argued that the disease spread from person to person. [ME-04, ME-06, ME-08, ME-16]
- **The Church:** a quarter of the pope's court died; so many priests died that a bishop let the dying confess to laypeople, "even to a woman". [CH-02, CH-05]

5. ACCURACY AND RESEARCH (3:45–4:30)

- 103 facts from 49 sources (Britannica, peer-reviewed journals such as *Nature* and *PNAS*, university sites, and primary sources like Boccaccio, Guy de Chauliac and Ibn Battuta). Every fact in the game is tied to a source.
- We show where historians disagree: the death toll, rats versus human fleas, how hard Spain was hit, conflicting dates, and a famous poem from Aleppo that was long mistaken for a factual record of the plague's route. [DB-01, ME-10, CI-18, TL-04, CI-21]
- We avoided anachronisms: no beaked plague-doctor masks (invented 1619), and quarantine appears only as "what came next" (Ragusa, 1377). [ME-11, ME-14]

6. BALANCE AND TESTING (4:30–4:50)

- We tested the rules with thousands of computer-played games. Home cities start with different amounts of money so that none of them dominates, and a balanced strategy beats pure greed. The same games time the rounds: Quick Play takes about 20 minutes for 4 players. Full results are in the simulation report (docs/simulation-report.md).

7. CLOSE (4:50–5:00)

- "In *Ports of Plague* you can't stop the Black Death. You can only decide what kind of family you'll be when it comes. That was true in 1348, too."
- Invite classmates to play; the Rule Book and Research Sheet are printed and available.

Fact codes in brackets refer to the Historical Research Sheet.